Experience - 140

Goldman Sachs
SDE 1
Interview Experience



Summary

📌 **Job Role**: SDE
🔢 **Number of Rounds**: 7
📜 **Offer Status**: Rejected
📍 **Location**: - Delhi
👤 **Candidate Name**: Not disclosing due to signed NDA

Interview Process:

- I applied to Goldman Sachs through an employee referral. The entire interview process was quite structured and spread across one online assessment followed by five interview rounds.
- Here’s a breakdown of the process:
  - Online Assessment
  - Round 1 - Coderpad (1 hour)
  - Round 1 Extension - Coderpad (30 mins)
  - Round 2 - Coderpad (1 hour)
  - Round 3 - Coderpad (1 hour)
  - Round 4 - Design (1 hour)
  - Round 5 - Hiring Manager (1 hour)

Preparation Guide

- I mainly relied on solving problems on LeetCode and going through interview experiences shared by other candidates. For context, I also interviewed at a few other companies around the same time. You may find these useful:
  - PayPal Interview Experience
  - MakeMyTrip Interview Experience
  - Arcesium Interview Experience

Round 1: Online Assessment

- 🕒 **Duration**: 60 Minutes
- 📈 **Difficulty Level**: Easy

- **Experience**:
- The online assessment included LeetCode-style Easy level problems. Unfortunately, I do not remember the exact problems asked in this round.

- **Key Learnings:**
- Be comfortable with basic array and string manipulation problems.
- Practice solving problems quickly, as time is limited.

Round 2: Coderpad

- 🕒 **Duration**: 60 Minutes
- 📈 **Difficulty Level**: Medium

- **Experience:**
- The round had two coding questions:
- Deepest Node in a Directed Graph
- (Previously asked in GS rounds) - Reference
- Find the Winner of the Circular Game
- I was able to complete the first question comfortably. However, I couldn't finish the second one within time. I was almost done but didn’t manage to run it fully. Interestingly, the interviewer suggested a 30-minute extension round to try a new question — a gesture I really appreciated.

- **Key Learnings:**
- Time management is crucial.
- Don’t hesitate to communicate your thought process. If you're close to a solution, the interviewer may be open to giving you more time.

Round 3: Coderpad

- 🕒 **Duration**: 30 Minutes
- 📈 **Difficulty Level:** Hard

- **Experience:**
- The problem was Median of Two Sorted Arrays.
- I began with the brute force approach of merging both arrays and finding the median. The interviewer then asked a follow-up:
- Follow-up: Merge two sorted arrays without using extra space. The result should be reflected back in the two arrays.
- Example:
- Input: arr1: [1 5 7 9] arr2: [2 3 4 6] Output: arr1: [1 2 3 4] arr2: [5 6 7 9]

- **Key Learnings:**
- Always be ready to discuss trade-offs and improvements.
- Practice in-place algorithms; they come up frequently in follow-ups.

Round 4: Technical

- 🕒 **Duration**: 60 Minutes
- 📈 **Difficulty Level**: Medium

- **Experience**:
- House Robber II
- I initially implemented a top-down recursive solution. Later, I was asked to optimize it using a bottom-up dynamic programming approach.
- Candy Distribution
- I submitted a brute force $O(n^2)$ solution, which was accepted.

- **Key Learnings:**
- Dynamic programming is a must-have skill.
- Even brute force solutions can be acceptable if time runs short and the logic is correct.

Round 5: Coding

- 🕒 **Duration**: 60 Minutes
- 📈 **Difficulty Level:** Medium

- **Experience:**
- Question 1: Sort a very large file that cannot be fully loaded into memory.
- The interviewer hinted toward an external merge sort solution using disk space. I eventually arrived at the correct approach.
- Question 2: Java Concepts
- Covered a wide range of Java topics:
- Internals of HashMap
- Why HashMap load factor is 0.75
- Exception handling and specific output questions
- String creation and memory allocation in Java
- Singleton class implementation and thread safety
- Use cases for Singleton
- Method overloading vs overriding
- Access modifiers in the context of overriding
- **Key Learnings:**
- Be thorough with language-specific concepts, especially if you mention Java in your resume.
- System-level questions can be disguised as design problems — clarify constraints upfront.

Round 6: Coding

- 🕒 Duration: 60 Minutes
- 📈 Difficulty Level: Medium
- **Experience:**
- Quick overview of my past projects and the tech stack used.
- Design LinkedIn’s connection degree feature (finding the degree of connection between two users).
- I proposed a BFS-based solution.
- Implemented supporting classes as part of the LLD requirement.
- We dry ran through a test case where I identified and fixed a few bugs.
- Discussion on exception handling during DB read/write operations.
- I could not answer this very well due to lack of exposure.
- Parsing a file from memory and writing it to DB using multiple threads while maintaining order.
- I suggested multi-threaded reading and single-threaded writing.
- The interviewer didn’t seem fully convinced, and we ran out of time.

Round 6: Coding

- **Key Learnings:**
- Low-level design is expected to be both conceptual and code-based.
- Handling system design edge cases (e.g., thread safety, exception handling) is important.

Round 7: Hiring Manager

- **Duration**: 60 Minutes
- 📈 **Difficulty Level**: Medium

- **Experience:**
- This round focused on behavioral questions and cultural fit.
- Questions included:
- Brief project discussion
- Why do you want to leave your current firm?
- What are you looking for in your next opportunity?
- Why Goldman Sachs?
- Hypothetical: How would you handle sharing confidential data mistakenly with the wrong client?
- Strengths and weaknesses
- Your proudest professional moment
- Egg Dropping Puzzle

- **Key Learnings:**
- Be honest and thoughtful in behavioral interviews.
- Use the STAR format (Situation, Task, Action, Result) when possible.
- Puzzle questions may still be asked in hiring rounds, so don’t skip them in your prep.

Final Thoughts:

- Here are a few key takeaways from my Goldman Sachs interview experience:
- Be Prepared for Extensions: Some interviewers might be open to giving you extra time if they see potential — be transparent about your approach.
- Dynamic Programming & Graphs: These topics appeared multiple times. Make sure you have a strong grip on them.
- Java Fundamentals: Knowing language-specific internals helped a lot in the interview rounds.
- LLD Requires Code: It’s not just about talking through design — you may be asked to implement core classes and logic.
- Behavioral Rounds Matter: Prepare your narratives and reflect on past experiences.
- Overall, the experience was quite comprehensive, and I appreciated the structured yet flexible approach taken by the interviewers.

Experience Link

Thank You

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